An MBA from London, Akash was first thrust into the spotlight in 2017, when his aunt introduced him to the cadre at a rally. He was formally inducted into the party only in 2019, and was part of all public meetings of the Samajwadi Party-BSP alliance ahead of the Lok Sabha polls that year. In a post-poll organisational rejig that May, Akash was named BSP national coordinator. His father, Mayawati's younger brother Anand Kumar, was made vice-president—second in hierarchy. So far, Akash has been overseeing party affairs outside UP and Uttarakhand, and led its efforts in the three heartland states and Telangana. Now he's likely to play an active role in party activities back home too.

Not everyone is enthused. By passing on the baton to kin, critics say, Mayawati is going against BSP founder Kanshi Ram

This, even though the BSP could win just two seats in Rajasthan, down from its tally of six in 2018, and drew a blank in the remaining three states. That's not out of sync with the BSP's general graph of late. In the 2022 assembly polls, a decade after Mayawati's last term as CM ended, the BSP could win only one seat in UP. Its vote share stood at 12.7 per cent, though the party's core base—the Dalits—constitutes 20 per cent of the state's electorate, half of them from Mayawati's Jatav caste.

Even in these straitened circumstances, the BSP is a potent, unpredictable presence. No wonder observers are keen to know Mayawati's next move. Insiders claim the party will go solo in 2024, though a final decision on any possible alliance could be announced on her birthday on January 15. The near term will shape the future skies—for Akash and the party. ■



WEST BENGAL

A CLASH OF TEMPLE BELLS

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

From organising Kashi-style Ganga *aartis* along the Hooghly in Kolkata to building replicas of Vaishno Devi and Puri Jagannath, the Trinamool Congress has in recent years striven to match every step of its main adversary, the BJP, in bursts of demonstrative Hinduism. Promoting religious tourism in West Bengal is only a virtuous byproduct here—the primary realm being targeted is political. That's precisely why, with the 2024 Lok Sabha polls drawing near, the state is seeing a fresh spurt of action.

On December 24, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will land in Kolkata to attend a widely publicised event where a hundred thousand people will recite hymns from the Bhagavad Gita. But a fortnight before that, two TMC leaders were found attending an event modelled exactly on those lines, if on a smaller scale, at the Jagannath temple in Mahesh, Hooghly district. As if on cue, an association of Brahmins, the Paschim Banga Rajya Sanatan Brahmin Trust, approached Kolkata mayor and minister Firhad Hakim to seek the state government's assistance in organising a *Chandipaath*—a recitation of hymns to goddess Durga. Incidentally, the trust had protested the contentious Citizenship (Amendment) Act in 2019.

The Brigade Parade grounds in Kolkata—known for hosting gargantuan Left Front rallies in the past—will host the *Lokkho*